



EAST WEST UNIVERSITY

ASSIGNMENT

Semester: Spring-2026

Course Name: Emergence of Bangladesh

Course Code: GEN7226

Section No: 11

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Submission Date: 28/07/2026

Historical Importance of the 7th March Speech of Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman

Introduction

Even though East Pakistan was the numerical majority, by early 1971 it had suffered more than 20 years of political marginalization and economic exploitation under the Pakistani state. The 14 March speech given by Bangabandhu Sheikh Mujibur Rahman at the Racecourse Maidan in Dhaka is generally considered to be the turning point that transformed a constitutional grievance into a national movement for independence that eventually led to the Liberation War which resulted in the formation of Bangladesh (Banglapedia, n.d.).

Causes

The speech was a product of a particular sequence of political events. The Awami League, which campaigned on its Six-Point programme for regional autonomy, won an absolute majority in the National Assembly (Wikipedia contributors, 2024a) in the general election in December 1970, when 167 of the 169 seats allocated to East Pakistan were won. The Bengalis had already developed a sense of resentment due to the longstanding inequities in resource allocation, administrative representation and industrial investment between the two wings. The Awami League won a clear mandate, but President Yahya Khan indefinitely postponed the convening of the National Assembly on 1 March 1971, which was seen as a conspiracy by the West Pakistani military and political establishment to deprive Bengalis of their democratic right to govern (Bangladesh on Record, 2025). This delay caused spontaneous protest and strikes in East Pakistan, which set the background for Bangabandhu's speech to the nation.

Description

On 7 March 1971, Bangabandhu gave an impromptu speech of nineteen minutes before a million-plus crowd at the Racecourse Maidan (now Suhrawardy Udyan) (Wikipedia contributors, 2024b). He directed the people to make their houses a fortress and he proclaimed a non-cooperation movement, which involved closing the courts, offices and educational institutions indefinitely (Banglapedia, n.d.). His call for a fight for freedom and independence became the rallying call for the movement. Significantly, the address was a successful declaration of independence, but Bangabandhu refrained from a formal declaration of

independence, leaving a space for negotiation and maintaining a nominal unity with Pakistan, which prevented the immediate accusation of treason against him and ensured that he could fully mobilise the population.

Aftermath

The address brought together a divided people and led to mass non-cooperation throughout East Pakistan, with government offices, courts and businesses shutting down their normal functioning. It psychologically and organisationally equipped Bengalis for armed resistance which started eighteen days later on 25 March 1971 when the Pakistan Army launched Operation Searchlight against Bengalis (Dhaka Tribune, 2025). In 2017, the speech was included in the Memory of the World International Register by UNESCO, which declared that the speech was a document that had effectively proclaimed the independence of Bangladesh (UNESCO, n.d.).

Conclusion

The 7 March speech is one of the most significant political orations in history, and is often considered to have turned electoral betrayal into collective will. It has remained a rhetorical masterpiece, a strategy of ambiguity, and an emotional touchstone for Bangladesh's national identity and its memory of the struggle for self-determination.

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